

Social Bits Istanbul

KASA GALERI ISTANBUL, MAY 2010

Introduction

http://socialbits.org
Social Bits is a research group based in Linz, Austria focusing on the artistic output of social interactions in real world locations; specifically in urban environments, public spaces and unique architectural complexes. Social interaction is a sustained presence in all societies throughout history; however, the methods of interaction have radically evolved in recent years, aided and augmented by both technological developments and the sense of comfort generated by these developments. Our research studies and analyzes the collective information cloud created by humans worldwide, as well as introducing new mediums, materials and platforms to present the artistic results we discover.

Social Bits is interested not solely in the social data itself. Rather, it is the means of producing the data, and how it can be reflected back on society that interests us. The process of turning a human thought into digital information, then in turn putting the information in a physical context is what is intriguing.

Current members of Social Bits:
Mahir M. Yavuz is a designer and researcher who lives and works in Linz, Austria. He is currently engaged in doctoral studies in Interface Culture at the University of Art and Design Linz. Besides giving lectures at the same university, he also works as a senior researcher of graphic design at the Ars Electronica Futurelab.

Jayme Cochrane is an interaction designer currently based in Linz. After receiving a BSc in Interactive Arts (focus Interaction Design) from Simon Fraser University in Canada, he moved to Linz to work at the Ars Electronica Futurelab. He is currently also pursuing a master's degree in Interface Culture at the University of Art and Design Linz.

h.o (Hide Ogawa, Taizo Zushi, Jun Yura and Emiko Ogawa) is an international media art group from Tokyo who creates conceptual artworks using a mixture

of media combined with digital technology. "h.o" derives from the chemical symbol for water, H2O, implying h.o's interest in various forms of communication between people. The activities and ideas of the group are inspired by little awareness that appear in everyday scenes and criticism on information-oriented society.

Concept

Life in cities is changing and being affected by the information coming from virtual platforms. The information we create in virtual worlds merges into real life and becomes a part of the daily life activities in cities. Cloud intelligence, online social networks and new technologies for urban displays such as media façades are showing us a new way to discover and to present the information created by the inhabitants of the city. The source of our information (which is, most of the time, about our real life experiences), the technology to share information (cloud computing and social networks) and the potential media to display the information converge into a new field that can be referred as Urban Information Interfaces. This ongoing convergence is about to create new fields of art and commerce as well as affecting the society of the city in an inevitable way.

In "Digital Ground", Malcolm McCullough discusses the "paradigm shift from building virtual worlds toward embedding information technology into the ambient social complexities of the physical world." In this new landscape of embedded technology, there is an opportunity for creating an interface between architecture and virtual information, turning architecture into an interactive surface for reading and exploring real-time social data from the Internet. At this point, is it possible to talk about a feedback loop that may occur between virtual platforms and psychical urban life in the future? What would happen if we let virtual information shape our environment and architecture? How would this feedback affect the speed and qualities of communication and the dynamics of our society?

In this exhibition, Social Bits aims to explore possible avenues of output and display the invisible information in the cityscape via media art. One of the most significant aspects of this exhibition is that the inhabitants of the city and the visitors of the gallery act as active participants of the exhibition and contribute shaping and forming the outcome of the interactive projects.

Artists Talks

In order to explain the concept and scope of Social Bits group as well as reviewing the exhibition projects in depth, we would like to organize one or two artist talks during the exhibition. The setup of the talks will be informal and the duration would be around ninety minutes.

Projects

URBANSPHERE WEARABLES by Mahir M. Yavuz (TR)



Urbansphere wearables aims to reflect the daily keywords of the city by utilizing the data streams of social networks as a source of fashion design. The project initiates "social sensors" (special filters and data gathering scripts that

follows twitter) in order to collect information on social networks created by different inhabitants of the same city. The data gathered is then visualized and turned into a fashion design that represents the recent topics and discussions of urban people.

As every online inhabitant of the city becomes a part of this production, the project brings online data to the streets, creating an ongoing interaction between the real and the virtual existence of the urban life. In the exhibition, visitors will see a set of unique wearables that contains the data from Istanbul. ructure and Personnel requirements are open to discussion.

URBAN MOOD by Mahir M. Yavuz (TR)



Urban Mood aims to visualize the real-time mood of Istanbul's citizens. It is a lighting, projection and sound installation situated in a small room. By publishing their personal thoughts on twitter, every Istanbulian becomes a part of this mood production. The installation continuously collects the data from tweeters in Istanbul, analyzing and summarizing each post in a single word. Through this keyword, the source tweets will create a typographic animation on the floor of the room, while lighting and sounds will change to suit the content of the keyword. The Urban Mood installation simulates the atmosphere of Istanbul for the gallery visitors.

COLLECTIVE DATA-MAPS by Social Bits (INT)



Collective Data Maps is a series of Istanbul city maps printed and prepared for exhibition visitors. With small tools and loose guidelines, visitors will participate to create a variety of physical data maps of Istanbul that reflect the nature of the city as told by its citizens.

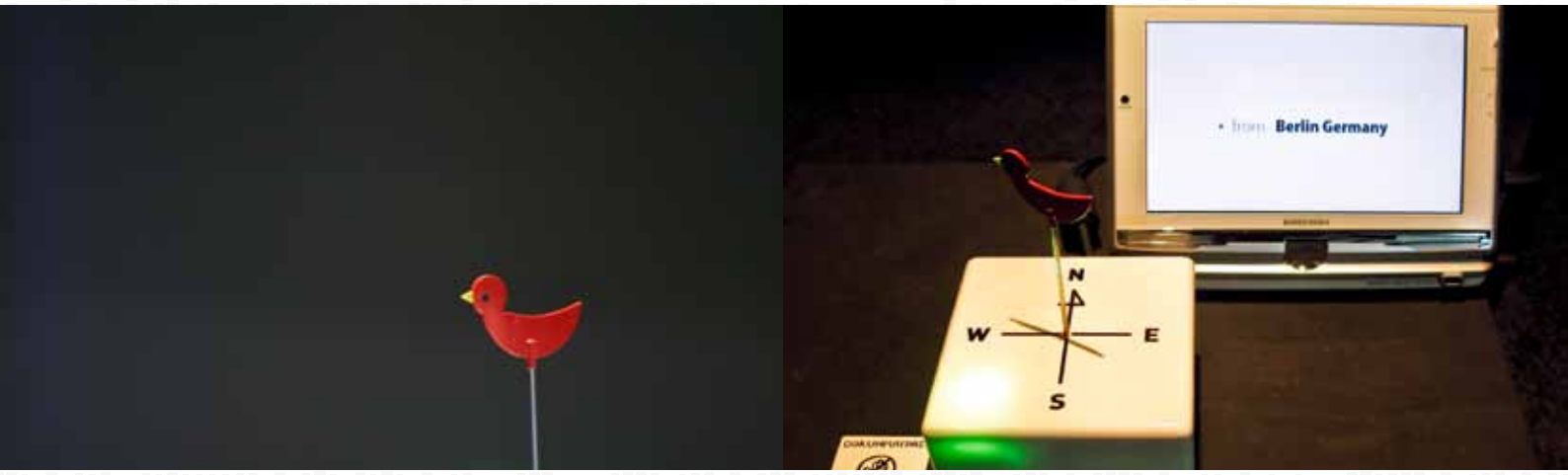
* Emotions of Istanbul: A set of colored LED lights will be provided alongside a large Istanbul city map. Lights will be grouped based on emotions. The question will be 'How do you feel about different parts of Istanbul?'

* Hotspots of Istanbul: Next to this map there will be same colored pins to place on spots in Istanbul. The question will be 'What is your favorite place in Istanbul?'

* Routes of Istanbul: Next to this map there will be pencils that allow people to draw shapes and sketch a path. The question will be 'What is your daily route in Istanbul?'

* Tags of Istanbul: Next to this map there will be many different keywords on sticky paper. Participants will be able to place a particular keyword on the map. The question will be 'Which keywords fits best to which location?'

KAZAMIDORI by h.o (JP)



kazamidori is a media gadget like weather vane to indicate the direction where visitors in a website are coming from in real-time. The weather vane is designed as a bird, like traditional weather vanes, as it will face the direction where the virtual 'wind' is coming from. Every day, visitors arrive at the website virtually and aims to physically display where the interested audience is, on a worldwide level.

In this exhibition, we will point the system towards the website of Social Bits. As a result, visitors to the gallery can see the direction where social bits is needed in the world, while imagining the subtle feelings of the virtual visitor.

FLUID DATA by Jayme Cochrane (CA)



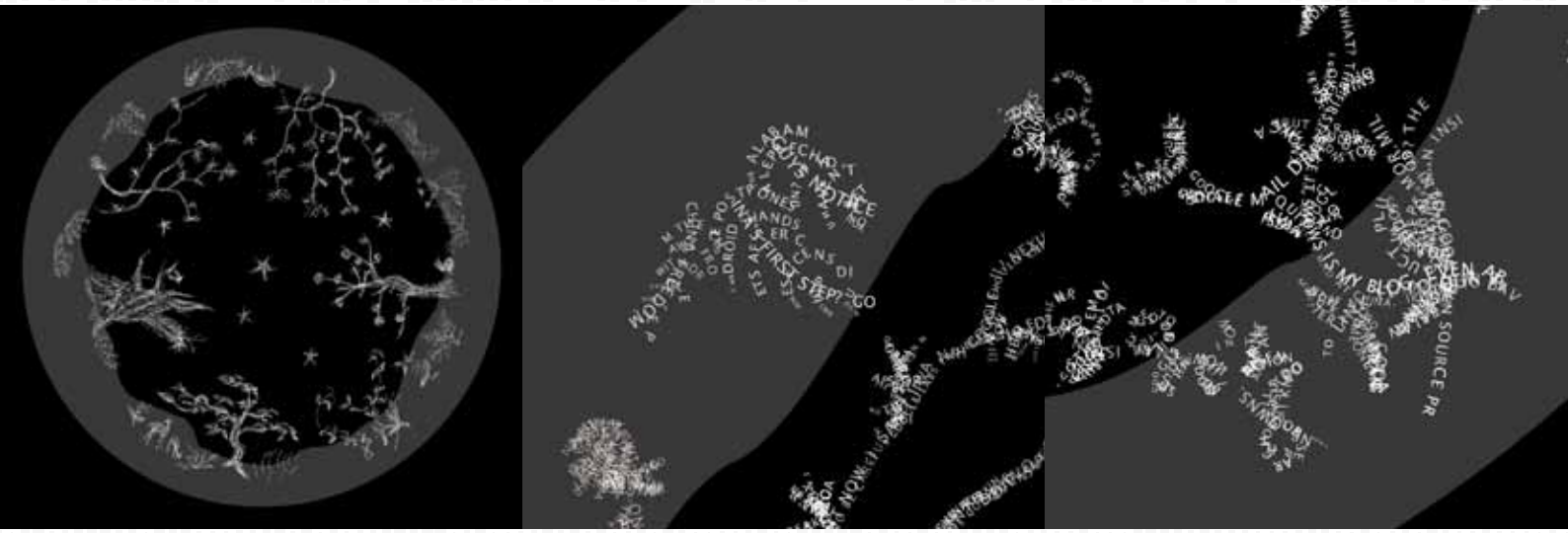
Fluid Data is a dynamic urban interface combining social data with architecture. The amount of location-specific content being put on the Internet is almost impossible to keep track of, and this project intends to make visible the pages and pages of data that most tend to miss. Centralized to Istanbul, real-time Twitter posts (both about Istanbul and by residents of the city) and news stories about Istanbul will gently flow throughout the architecture of the gallery. This seemingly endless flow of data will follow pipes, door frames, and other architectural elements as it moves around the room, showing viewers just how much data about the city is being created in real-time. Intending to highlight elements of the architecture, the data will follow paths both in and out of a room, appearing in the space via the Internet, flowing along the architecture, then disappearing again, back into the social data sphere.

NEWS LEAK by Jayme Cochrane (CA) and Tim Devine (AU)



News Leak is a motivated functional hybrid of real and digital cultures and media. Press a button on a wall to instantly receive a printed summary of the latest news from around the world, news of your current location, news of Internet cultures, events, trends and social media. News Leak acts as an urban intervention, a transitory media output device that provides a snapshot of local and global culture and happenings at the press of a button. It is light, consumable, disposable media. The aim is to cultivate a functional exchange between real space and virtual space, and showing how each space can augment and support the other. In the same vein as a traditional newspaper, News Leak has a target audience, a distinct style and type of content, and specific intervals and methods of distribution. Most publications are fundamentally focused on the target audience, and the target audience is defined by the content and distribution. However, as our everyday life begins to exist more in virtual spaces, and information about how we behave and act in these spaces is made more readily available, the more we should reflect and report about it: the more, 'we' should pertain to people active in both spaces.

SOCIALDRAW by Travis Kirton (CA) and h.o (JP)



SocialDraw is an application in which visitors can draw a typographic picture consisting of social information about Istanbul coming from Twitter, blogs and news stories. SocialDraw provides multi-linear control over the creation of typographic works through a gesture-based interface. In this exhibition, visitors can draw the Bosphorus Bridge in Istanbul by using SocialDraw. During the exhibition period, this symbolic monument in Istanbul will be drawn many times by many visitors, creating variations of a dynamic picture based on daily social information.

Technical Details & Costs

Travel:
Travel costs for 3 artists from Austria to Istanbul.

Accommodation:
Accommodation for 4 (Jayme, Emi, Hide, Taizo(h.o)) artists for a period of one week in Istanbul.

Space:
Small gallery (c. 150 sqm) with white walls
Lighting, Infrastructure and Personnel requirements are open to discussion.

Internet Connection:
High speed broadband Internet connection is required for some of the works.

Artist Talk:
Presentation setup with projectors. A podium or table & chairs for presenters and chairs for the audience.

Urbansphere Wearables:
10x Printing of the shirts.
10x Mannequins for the shirts. (Mahir)

Urban Mood:
100x Programmable RGB LED Lights
1x Projector (min. 1024x768 res.)
1x PC: Dell Inspiron 546 Desktop, 2gb RAM, Monitor for setup.
2x Loud Speaker (Monitor)

Collective Data-Maps:
4x Map Print (2x3m)
1000x Pins
1000x Led-pins
10x Pencils
1000x Printed Stickers

Kazamidori:
1x Pedestal (50cmx50cmx50cm)

Fluid Data:
1x Projector: Optoma HD65 ideally, any HD (min. 1024x768 res.)
1x PC: Dell Inspiron 546 Desktop, 2gb RAM, 256mb graphics card, Windows XP, Monitor for setup.

News Leak:
1x PC: Dell Inspiron 546 Desktop, 2gb RAM, Monitor for setup.
1x Thermal Receipt Printer

SocialDraw:
1x Wacom Cintiq 21UX
1x Workstation with OSX 10.5
1x A4 Printer
A4 Papers